Huai Bong Dairy Farm Opens Applications for the 2027 Young Cheesemaker Fellowship

Huai Bong Dairy Farm Co., Ltd. · Press release Ref. HB-PR-2026-09 · For immediate release · 21 September 2026

DAN KHUN THOT, Nakhon Ratchasima, 21 September 2026 – Huai Bong Dairy Farm today announced the third intake of the Huai Bong Young Cheesemaker Fellowship, a 14-week programme that teaches young smallholder dairy farmers to turn part of their own milk into fresh and short-aged cheese and sell it locally. The 2027 cohort will have 12 places, up from 8 places in each of the 2025 and 2026 cohorts, and the monthly stipend rises to 6,500 baht. Until the 2026 cohort the stipend was 5,000 baht per month.

"Most small farms in our area sell every litre to the collection centre at the same price, whatever the season," said Orathai Sukpracha, Managing Director of Huai Bong Dairy Farm. "We want young farmers to keep their herds, not sell them."

1. Programme dates and structure

The 2027 fellowship runs from Monday 11 January 2027 to Friday 16 April 2027 in three phases:

- **Phase 1, weeks 1–6 (11 January to 19 February):** full-time training in the Huai Bong creamery, Building 4, Monday to Friday from 07:30 to 16:00. Topics include milk hygiene, starter cultures, pressing and labelling.
- **Phase 2, weeks 7–12 (22 February to 2 April):** fellows make cheese on their own farms. A mentor from the Huai Bong creamery visits each fellow every second Thursday.
- **Phase 3, weeks 13–14 (5 to 16 April):** final assessment of each fellow's cheese and a public Market Day at the Huai Bong farm shop on Saturday 10 April 2027, where every fellow runs a stall.

Accommodation in the farm dormitory and three meals a day are provided free of charge during Phase 1 only.

2. Who can apply

Applicants must meet all of the following conditions:

- Aged 20 to 35 on 1 January 2027.
- Currently milking at least 5 and no more than 40 cows on a farm they run themselves or with their family.
- Delivering milk to a collection centre in Nakhon Ratchasima, Chaiyaphum or Buriram province.
- Able to attend all of Phase 1 in person.

Age exception. Applicants aged 36 to 40 on 1 January 2027 may also apply if they took over the day-to-day running of a family dairy farm on or after 1 January 2025. They must attach a letter from the village headman or the collection centre confirming the handover date. Former fellows of the 2025 or 2026 cohorts cannot apply again.

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3. What fellows receive

- **Stipend:** 6,500 baht per month for the four months from January to April 2027, paid by bank transfer on the last working day of each month.
- **Starter kit:** equipment worth about 38,000 baht, including a 50-litre stainless steel vat with heater, a screw cheese press, 20 moulds, a digital probe thermometer and a pH meter.
- **Certificate:** fellows who pass the final assessment receive the Huai Bong Cheesemaker Certificate at the Market Day.

Fellows keep all income from the cheese they make and sell during Phases 2 and 3. Huai Bong does not take a share and does not buy fellows' cheese.

4. Commitments and conditions

Fellows must attend at least 90 % of Phase 1 training days, which is 27 of the 30 days. A fellow who misses more than 3 days in Phase 1 without a medical certificate leaves the programme. In Phase 2, fellows must send a short weekly production log to their mentor by Sunday evening; the stipend for a month is withheld if two or more logs from that month are missing.

The starter kit becomes the fellow's property on successful completion of the programme. A fellow who leaves the programme for any reason before the end of week 12 must return the kit within 14 days. A fellow who leaves during Phase 3 keeps the kit but does not receive the certificate.

5. How to apply

1. Complete the application form online on the Huai Bong website or on paper at the farm office in Building 2, open Monday to Saturday from 08:00 to 17:00.
2. Attach a copy of your national ID card, your farm registration document, milk delivery slips for the last 3 months, and a one-page letter explaining what cheese you want to make and why.
3. Submit by 17:00 on Sunday 15 November 2026. Applications open on 1 October 2026; late applications are not accepted.

Shortlisted applicants are interviewed at the farm from 1 to 4 December 2026, and the final shortlist includes a visit to the applicant's own farm. Results are announced by telephone and on the website on 11 December 2026.

About Huai Bong Dairy Farm

Huai Bong Dairy Farm is a family-owned dairy farm in Dan Khun Thot district, Nakhon Ratchasima, founded in 1998. Its on-farm creamery opened in 2019. The Young Cheesemaker Fellowship started in 2025 and has trained 16 fellows from three provinces so far.

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